

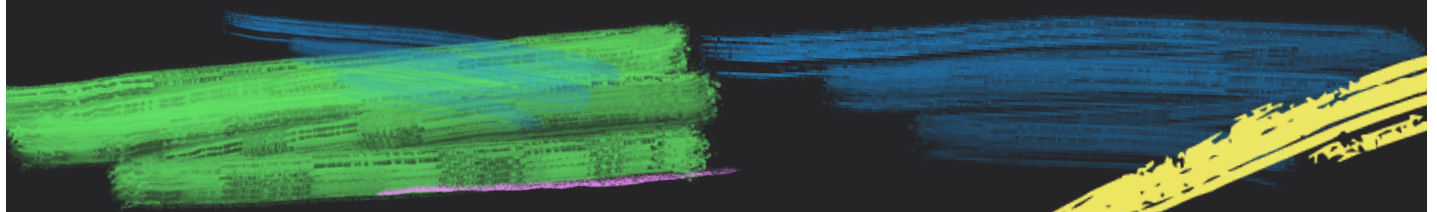


REACH, A BRAND OF REFRESH · PUBLIC-SERVING DIVISION

Know the Need

A summary for commercial customers and nonprofit agency recipients alike. How a needs assessment people answer for themselves, connected to resources and services, gives an employer or a nonprofit agency an immediate read on what its people need and where to invest.

Summary · about a 9-minute read



What is in here. One idea, followed from a person's first five minutes, to what an employer or a nonprofit agency learns about the people it serves, to how the work gets paid for on each side and what to call it. The last section holds every question and answer for the operations team. There is also a [PDF of this summary](#).

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SECTION 1

The insight

Every organization that serves people gets asked the same question. A nonprofit agency hears it from its board and its funders: what do the people we serve actually need? An employer hears it from its leaders every time it sets the total rewards budget: what does our workforce actually need? Today the honest answer is usually a guess, assembled months later from intake forms, program enrollments, benefits utilization reports, and whoever asked for help loudly enough to be noticed.

One sentence. When a person answers fourteen plain questions about their own life, they see their next step in that moment, their employer or agency sees the need as it forms, and a resource or a case manager is in front of them before they leave.

That joins four things that have always been kept apart: finding out what someone needs, getting them what they need, knowing what a whole workforce or community needs, and deciding where the next dollar should go. On REACH they happen in one motion, for a commercial customer and a nonprofit agency recipient alike.

SECTION 2

Community needs assessments exist. This is a different kind.

Assessing need is not new, on either side. Tax-exempt hospitals complete a Community Health Needs Assessment every three years, and Community Action agencies complete a community assessment on a similar cycle. Health systems use social-needs screeners such as PRAPARE and the CMS Accountable Health Communities screening tool. Human services agencies use self-sufficiency matrices, the best known being the Arizona Self-Sufficiency Matrix, and closed-loop referral platforms to send and track referrals. Employers run annual engagement surveys, read benefits utilization reports, and benchmark total rewards against other employers. Each is valuable, and each covers one part of the problem.

Community needs assessments

Describe a community

Surveys, focus groups, and public data, published every few years. They guide strategy, but they cannot help the person who answered.

Screeners

Find a risk

Usually a checklist that ends in a flag for staff. What happens next depends on who reads it, and when.

Matrices

Rate a household

Usually scored by a case manager inside one program and reported upward. The person rarely sees the result.

Referral platforms

Send a referral

Move a person between agencies, but only after someone else has decided what the need is.

Engagement surveys

Measure how work feels

Ask about the job and the manager, once a year. They rarely ask about food, housing, or childcare at home, and they connect no one to help.

Benefits reports and benchmarks

Look back, or look sideways

Show what a workforce used last year and what other employers offer, not what this workforce needs now.

What makes this one of a kind

THE PERSON PLACES THEMSELVES

Each of the fourteen areas asks one question with five answers in plain language, and the person picks the one that sounds like their life. Nobody scores them. Control over your own circumstances predicts how a life goes, so the assessment starts by handing that control back.

THE ANSWER IS THE FIRST STEP OF THEIR JOURNEY

Each answer sets the stage where the person's journey begins: Stabilize, Connect, Build Skills, or Maintain. Each stage already has three written steps with timeframes, roughly 630 across the fourteen areas. The person leaves already on their way, with a first step and a date, not a flag in someone else's queue.

ACCESS HAPPENS AT THE ANSWER

The area chooses the kind of resource, and the answer chooses how urgent it is. REACH, or the organization itself, then surfaces the resources and programs that fit, near enough to reach. Where nothing fits yet, the organization finds the resource or budgets for it, so it can be made available. The assessment is not a report about need. It is the search.

IT SHOWS WHERE TO INVEST

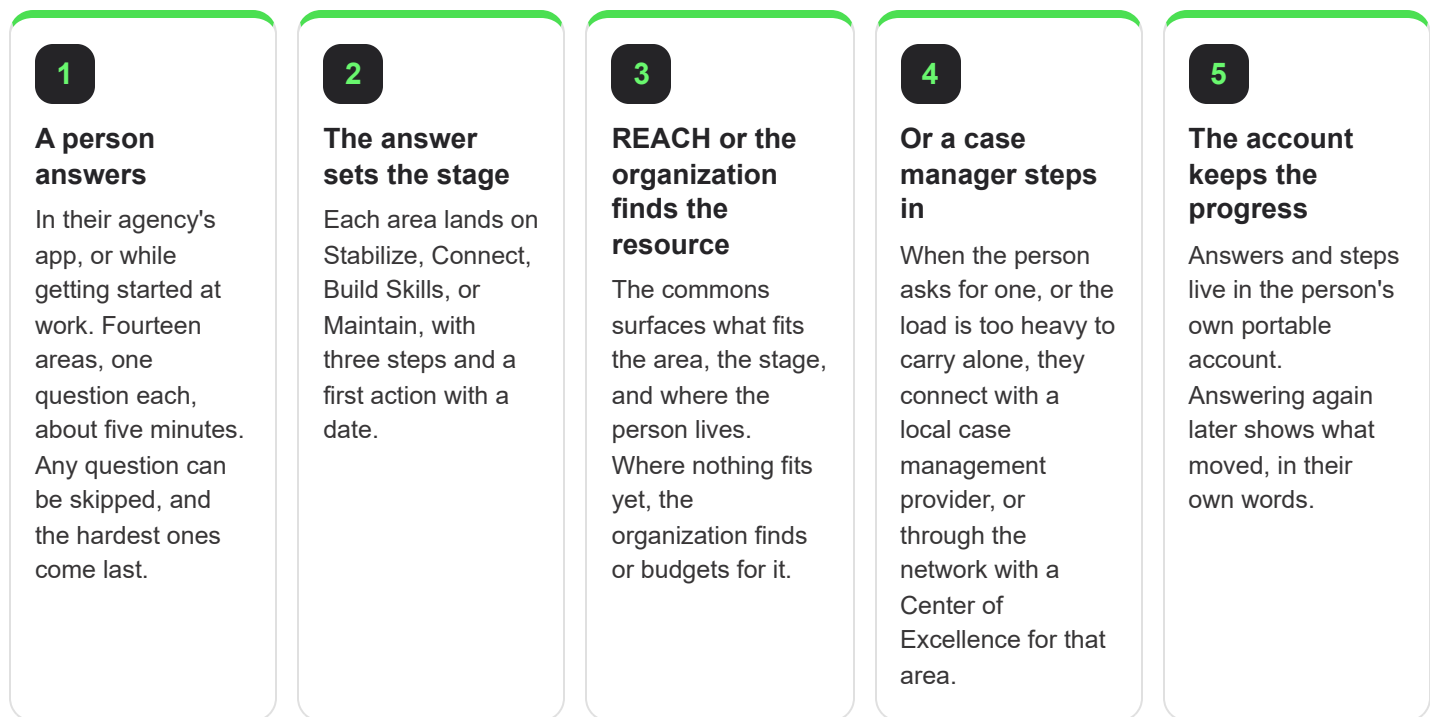
Pooled by area and by tag, the same answers tell an employer or a nonprofit agency which benefits, resources, and programs to add, and for whom. A tag is a label on a person's account, such as where they came in, a site, or a program.

The claim we can defend. Community needs assessments describe a community after the fact, screeners flag a person for someone else to act on, and engagement surveys and benchmarks tell an employer how work feels or what peers offer. We have not found another personalized needs assessment that gives a person access to resources and programs the moment they answer and, from the same answers, tells an employer or a nonprofit agency what to invest in next. If one exists, we want to learn from it.

SECTION 3

How it works, end to end

From where the person sits, whether they are an employee, a participant, a community member, or a volunteer, they answered a few questions and left with help in hand. The machinery stays out of sight.



Three routes lead out of the same five minutes: a resource right away, a case manager, or both. The person's choice decides.

A person is never a score. There is no total. Fourteen areas are fourteen results, and a level describes a situation, never a person.

SECTION 4

Part of onboarding, for both kinds of customer

The assessment belongs at the front door. When a commercial customer or a nonprofit agency joins, its people take it as part of getting started, and the organization gets its first clear read on the people it serves in weeks rather than years.

Commercial customers

Total rewards built on the workforce you have

During onboarding, an employer learns what its workforce actually needs, from the physiological basics of food, housing, and a ride to work, up through mental health, family care, and connection. Work-life balance and overall wellbeing become visible instead of guessed at, so the total rewards budget goes to the benefits, perks, and supports this workforce will actually use.

Nonprofit agency recipients

Know participants, community members, and volunteers

Nonprofit agencies and public-sector recipients of the REACH grant get the same read on the people they serve: participants, community members, volunteers, and their own staff. A community assessment done every few years gains a live companion, every person who answered already has a next step, and the grant pays for it on the agency's behalf.

The two customers buy for different reasons and learn the same thing. Employers that give hourly and gig workers access to supports they would not otherwise have are already one of REACH's commercial buyers, and the assessment shows them what to offer first. Nonprofit agencies already carry the mission, and the assessment shows them where their people are, so the next program, grant request, or partnership goes where it will land.

In the rollout: the answers curate Phase 2

The rollout itself is the first use. As part of launch, an agency or an employer invites everyone who downloads the app to take the check-in. Phase 1 opens with the resources already on hand. The answers then curate Phase 2: which resources to invest in, which to find or budget for, and which people to guide toward what already exists.

1

Launch

Everyone who downloads the app is invited to take the check-in in their first week.

2

Answer

Each person gets a first step and the resources available today, right away.

3

Read the pooled view

After the first few weeks, the organization sees where the weight sits and where little is on offer.

4

Curate Phase 2

Invest in, find, or budget for what the answers call for, and guide people toward what already fits.

The line neither one crosses. Answers belong to the person. An employer or an agency's leadership sees pooled counts only, never a person and never a group small enough to point to one. Taking the assessment is voluntary. For employers, answers are never used for hiring, pay, promotion, or discipline, and because health and mental health questions asked on behalf of an employer carry disability, health privacy, and wellness program rules, counsel reviews any employer launch before it starts. The same protections hold when an agency looks at its own staff and volunteers.

SECTION 5

What the organization sees

Once people are answering, the same answers, pooled, tell an employer or a nonprofit agency something it has never had in real time: what the people it serves need, area by area, this month.

Where the weight sits

How many people are at Stabilize in Housing, or at Connect in Transportation, and whether that number is growing. Fourteen distributions, not one index.

Where the commons is thin

The areas where people land at Stabilize and little is nearby to offer. That tells the organization what to find or budget for, partners what to add, and funders what to fund.

What moved

Whether people who started at Stabilize reached Connect, by area and over time. This is the evidence funders, boards, and leadership increasingly ask for.

For a commercial customer: 1,200 employees

An employer with 1,200 employees onboards. In Nutrition, 600 of them, half the workforce, land at a stable level: they can steadily provide the food they and their families need. Only five answer that food isn't reliable right now.

What that changes. The obvious move would be bulletin boards about SNAP and case manager training on food assistance, and it would speak to almost no one. For this workforce the useful investment is eating well on a budget: recipes, healthy eating challenges, and help planning a food budget. The money that would have gone to a food assistance campaign can go to the area where the weight actually sits.

The five are not forgotten. Each one was linked to food help, and offered a case manager, privately, the moment they answered. The employer's view shows them as "fewer than 10," because a number that small could point to a person.

For a nonprofit agency recipient: 900 participants and volunteers

A nonprofit agency onboards its participants, community members, and volunteers, about 900 people in all. In Transportation, 360 of them land at Stabilize or Connect: no reliable ride, or rides that often fall through. In Housing, most land at a stable level.

What that changes. The agency had planned its next grant request around a housing workshop. The answers point to rides instead: help with car repairs, transit passes, and volunteer drivers for work and appointments. The budget, the next grant application, and the volunteer recruitment all go where the weight actually sits.

In both cases the lesson is the same, and it is the case for fourteen distributions instead of one wellbeing score. A single index would have averaged the few people in hardship into the many who are steady, and hidden both. *The numbers in both examples are illustrative.*

What exists today. The individual experience is written: the questions, the answers, the stages, and the steps. The pooled view is a design, not a finished product. It must show pooled counts only and never an individual, it must hide any group too small to keep people anonymous, and it must count only people who agreed to share. The account belongs to the person, and that does not change when their answers help a workforce or a community see itself.

How it pays for itself

The assessment does not add a new cost for either customer. It points money that already exists at the right person sooner. Employers already budget for benefits and wellbeing. Private, public, and restricted funding already pays nonprofit agencies for outreach, screening, and enrollment. This puts that spending where the need is.

THE COMMERCIAL CUSTOMER GAINS

Total rewards spent where they land

- Benefits, perks, and supports matched to what its workforce actually needs
- Less spent on programs few employees use, more on the ones they will
- Onboarding and platform fees are its investment in that view

THE NONPROFIT AGENCY RECIPIENT GAINS

Funded work, found sooner

- The REACH grant, or the agency's own restricted funding, pays for the resource toolkit as procured technology
- People who need what the agency is already funded to deliver find it sooner, and enroll when they are eligible
- Outcome evidence that helps it renew and expand what it wins

THE CASE MANAGEMENT PROVIDER INVESTS

Curated marketing

- Shown to the people whose answers match what it does, by area, stage, and place
- Funds curated marketing, not a fee per referral
- Uses the resource toolkit with the people it serves

REFRESH EARNS

Marketing and tools, not referrals

- Onboarding and platform fees from commercial customers
- Curated technology services paid through the REACH grant for nonprofit agency recipients
- Curated marketing funded by case management providers

How curated marketing is priced is still open. **Decentralized Mission Services** sets out how agencies, funders, and people themselves pay for the services on the network.

The boundary that keeps this clean. Refresh facilitates and equips. It does not employ the case managers, does not set eligibility, and does not take a cut that varies with whether someone enrolls in a public benefit. Refresh is paid to market a case management provider to the people it can help, never for a referral. An answer on the assessment is never billable in itself, and counsel reviews how curated marketing is priced before any provider of a publicly reimbursed service takes part.

And the revenue follows the people. Organizations that hold a large, active, well-served population earn from it. The assessment is how that population learns what it needs, and a reason to keep coming back.

SECTION 7

What we will not do

Screen without a way to respond

Asking someone about food and then showing an empty list is extraction, not help. Launch where there is something to offer, and use the pooled view to find or budget for the rest.

Treat an answer as an emergency

A hard answer describes a situation, not a crisis. Emergencies come from what a person tells someone, and each organization's own crisis policy decides who responds.

Score, rank, or label people

No total, no ranking of people, and no level shown as who someone is. People know when they are being judged.

Show an employer one person's answers

Employers see pooled counts only, and nothing an employee answers is ever used in a decision about their job.

Sell referrals

Providers fund curated marketing. No one pays for a person.

Claim outcomes we have not measured

There is no outcome data yet. What we have is a design traceable to Marmot, Mullainathan and Shafir, Hicks, Desmond, and Schwartz, and to teams who have practiced this for a century.

SECTION 8

What to call it

Two things need names: what a person takes, and what an organization sees. Neither carries the REACH name. REACH is the grant program that pays for this on behalf of others, so the names belong to Refresh and to the person's own journey, and they have to work for an employee and a participant alike.

The family name

Refresh Personal Journeys is the working name for the whole experience: the questions, the stage each answer sets, and the steps that follow. It names what the person gets, a journey that is their own, rather than something done to them.

What a person takes

"Assessment" is accurate, but it reads like a test someone can fail. Each option below keeps the Personal Journeys name and changes that one word.

First choice, not decided	Alternative	Plain
Personal Journeys Check-In Warm, plain, and repeatable: you check in again later and see what moved. Works inside a nonprofit agency's own app ("Goodwill Marion Check-In, powered by Refresh") and at work without needing an explanation.	Personal Journeys Starting Point Says exactly what the first answer is: the first step of the journey. Reads less naturally the second and third time someone answers.	Personal Journeys Assessment What funders, procurement teams, benefits buyers, and RFPs already search for. Best kept for proposals and contracts rather than the screen a person sees.

Other words that work in place of "assessment" are **Journey Map**, which fits the journey idea, **Self-Check**, and **Profile**. Words to avoid are **screening**, which sounds like an eligibility test, **evaluation**, which sounds like judgment, and **snapshot**, because the point is a path forward, not a picture of what is wrong.

What an organization sees

Know the Need is the working name for the pooled view that an employer or a nonprofit agency sees. It is short, and it says what the view is for.

On "culture management." It fits the commercial side, where the buyer is HR and total rewards. It does not fit a person at a food pantry, who is not managing a culture. One answer is a single instrument with two labels: the Personal Journeys Check-In for people, and a culture and wellbeing view for employers. None of these names has had a trademark search.

SECTION 9

Decisions this needs

THE POOLED VIEW

What employers and agencies see, which tags they can filter by, the smallest group ever shown, how consent is asked, and who can see what. This needs a privacy review before any customer sees pooled answers.

EMPLOYER LAUNCH

Counsel's review of health and mental health questions offered through an employer, how voluntary participation is kept voluntary, and the smallest group an employer can see.

THE GRANT

Which curated services the REACH grant covers for nonprofit agency recipients, and how that differs from what a commercial customer pays at onboarding.

WHO GETS A CASE MANAGER

The rule that offers one, set against real case manager capacity in each market. The person's own choice always decides.

THE MODEL

How curated marketing is priced for case management providers, and counsel's review of it for providers of publicly reimbursed services.

ALL FOURTEEN, OR A SHORT FIRST PASS

Scarcity argues against asking fourteen questions of someone in crisis. The alternative is a short first pass, with more depth only where it is needed.

THE NAME

Which option in Section 8 people and customers see, followed by a trademark search.

SECTION 10

For the operations team: the questions and answers

Everything needed to set up the check-in is in this section. Ask the questions in this order, which saves the hardest ones for last. Answers always appear from A to E, and a person sees letters only, never a level name.

Read or show this first. These answers help us connect you with resources that meet what you need right now. This is about your situation, not about you. There are no right or wrong answers, and nothing here is a score. There are 14 short questions about different parts of life. For each one, pick the answer that sounds most like your life right now. If a question doesn't fit you, or you'd rather not answer, skip it. Your answers help us find where to start, and you decide what to work on first.

The fourteen questions

1 · Transportation

How would you best describe your current transportation situation?

- A** I have no access to reliable transportation.
- B** I rely entirely on others, public transit, or options that often fall through.
- C** I have some transportation but struggle with cost or reliability.
- D** I have consistent, affordable transportation of my own.
- E** I own and maintain a reliable vehicle, or have steady independent access to transportation.

2 · Communication

How well are you able to communicate with others and get the tools you need (phone, internet, computer, language support)?

- A** I can't communicate well. I don't have a working phone, internet, or computer, or I can't understand the information I need.
- B** I try to communicate but often struggle with devices, internet, or language.
- C** I can communicate but need help with technology or understanding information.
- D** I communicate well and have the tools I need most of the time.
- E** I have strong communication skills and full access to the tools and support I need.

3 · Education Stability

How are learning and education going for you or your family, whether that's school, training, or building new skills?

- A** I can't take part in school, training, or learning right now, or my child is struggling badly in school.
- B** I want to keep learning, but I often miss school or training, or cost, time, or other barriers get in the way.
- C** I'm learning or supporting my child's school, but I need help choosing a path or staying consistent.
- D** I'm on track with school, training, a new skill, or my child's education.
- E** I keep investing in myself: learning new skills, growing my knowledge, and planning my next step.

4 · Workforce Development

How would you best describe your current employment situation?

- A** I'm unemployed and not doing any job-related activities.
- B** I'm employed part-time or in temporary jobs without benefits.
- C** I'm employed full-time but rely on public assistance to meet basic needs.
- D** I'm employed full-time with enough income and benefits to meet my needs without assistance.
- E** I have a stable career with room to advance and financial security.

5 · Financial Stability

How would you best describe your current financial situation?

- A** I don't have reliable income and can't meet basic needs.
- B** I have income but struggle to keep up with bills and often fall behind.
- C** I can meet basic needs but rely on assistance or have very little savings.
- D** I pay bills on time, have some savings, and use no assistance.
- E** I have long-term stability, savings, and I am building wealth.

6 · Housing

How would you best describe your current housing situation?

- A** I'm homeless right now, or staying in a shelter or somewhere temporary.
- B** My housing is unstable. I'm at risk of eviction or doubling up with others.
- C** I'm in stable housing but rely on a subsidy or assistance to stay there.
- D** I have secure housing paid for with my own income, without assistance.
- E** I own or lease independently and maintain it with savings and stability.

7 · Nutrition

How would you describe your access to food for you and your family in the past three months?

- A** Food isn't reliable right now, and some days I go without a meal.
- B** Public assistance is how I'm able to eat consistently.
- C** I piece food together with my income and some public assistance.
- D** I can steadily provide the food my family and I need.
- E** I can buy what my family and I need, and choose what we enjoy.

8 · Environmental Health

How would you best describe the condition of your home and its effect on your health?

- A** My home or surroundings are unsafe or unhealthy: mold, pests, toxins, unsafe temperatures, structural issues, poor air.
- B** My home has ongoing problems that cause discomfort, stress, or health issues.
- C** My home is mostly healthy, but I rely on support to keep it that way.
- D** My home is consistently safe, clean, and healthy, with routines that prevent problems.
- E** My home is stable and healthy, and I maintain it for the long term.

9 · Health Care Access & Quality

How well are you able to get the health care you need, for yourself or your family?

- A** I can't get health care right now, or I don't have a doctor I can go to.
- B** I can get some care, but cost, rides, or other things often get in the way.
- C** I get care when I need it but need help staying consistent or understanding what to do.
- D** I get regular care, follow medical advice, and keep up with appointments.
- E** I take charge of my health, keep regular checkups, and know how to use the health system.

10 · Health Behavior Promotion

How are your daily health habits: eating, sleeping, movement, smoking or vaping, and substance use?

- A** My health habits are hurting me right now, and they're hard to change without help.
- B** I try to stay healthy, but stress, time, or money often get in the way.
- C** I have some healthy habits but need support to stay consistent or avoid unhealthy ones.
- D** I have strong healthy habits most days and avoid things that harm my health.
- E** I make healthy choices every day, stay active, and practice long-term wellness habits.

11 · Family Care

How well are you able to care for the people in your home who depend on you (children, partner, an older parent, or other family)?

- A** I'm struggling to meet the basic needs of my family or household.
- B** I try, but I often feel overwhelmed or can't keep up with caregiving.
- C** I'm doing okay but still need help staying organized or supporting others.
- D** I meet my family's needs well and have good routines at home.
- E** My family or household feels strong, supported, and connected.

12 · Social Connection & Support Groups

How would you best describe your level of social connection, support, and time with others?

- A** I feel isolated, have no one I can rely on, and rarely spend time with others.
- B** I have limited social contact and few supportive relationships.
- C** I have some connections but rely on groups or services to stay socially engaged.
- D** I spend time with others regularly, keep supportive relationships, and feel connected.
- E** I have strong, healthy relationships and actively keep meaningful connections.

13 · Mental Health

How are you feeling most days?

- A** I feel really bad or overwhelmed and don't know how to handle it.
- B** I feel stressed or worried a lot, and it makes daily life hard.
- C** I'm doing okay, but I need support or tools to stay steady.
- D** I feel mostly good and have healthy habits that help me stay that way.
- E** I feel strong and calm, and I do things regularly to take care of my mental health.

14 · Safety, Violence Prevention & Environmental Stability

How would you best describe your current level of safety for yourself and your family, at home, in your surroundings, and in the community?

- A** I feel unsafe because of threats, violence, or dangerous conditions where I live or spend time.
- B** I have ongoing safety concerns or unpredictable environments.
- C** I feel mostly safe but rely on supports to reduce risks or manage safety issues.
- D** I feel consistently safe, with routines and practices that keep me and my home safe.
- E** I feel very safe and keep strong habits that prevent risk for me and my family long term.

Every question also offers **Skip this question**. Education Stability, Workforce Development, and Family Care also offer "it doesn't apply to me." A skip is recorded as skipped, never as A.

Staff key

A	Level 1 · Critical. The journey starts at Stabilize.
B	Level 2 · Vulnerable. The journey starts at Connect.
C	Level 3 · Dependent. The journey starts at Build Skills.
D	Level 4 · Independent. The journey starts at Maintain.
E	Level 5 · Thriving. The journey starts at Maintain.
SKIPPED	Not scored, and never treated as A.

Before launch. Show the help numbers, 911, 988, and 211, to everyone at the end, whatever they answered, and confirm them against the organization's own crisis policy. Ask the Safety question in private, and never write its details into a shared record. No single answer triggers an emergency alert on its own; emergencies come from what a person says.